

// STATE OF THE PUBLIC LIBRARY – GUJARAT

THE ₹10,000 LIBRARY

Gujarat — the state where India’s modern public-library movement began, in Baroda a century ago — today runs roughly one public library for every 20,000 people, funds nine in ten of them as revocable grants to private societies, and caps the village library at ₹10,000 a year. There is no library cess. Reading is provisioned at the state’s discretion, and thinnest where the need is widest.

KEY MESSAGES

1. **~3,500 libraries for ~70 million people** — about **one public library per 20,000 residents**; for state-run libraries alone, one per ~235,000.
2. **The state runs almost none of it directly.** Just 298 libraries (8%) are government-run; **~3,214 (92%) are grant-in-aid** — society or local-body libraries kept alive by annual grants the state can withdraw.
3. **The grant ladder is regressive.** The **2,598 village libraries** — the largest and most rural tier — are capped at **₹10,000 a year (₹833 a month)**, the lowest rung. City libraries get ₹1,00,000.
4. **No cess, no right.** Unlike Tamil Nadu or Karnataka, Gujarat levies no library cess. Funding is a discretionary grant scheme re-issued since 1974; the 2001 Act created a council, not a fund.
5. **India’s own benchmark, unmet.** India’s first library law — the Madras Public Libraries Act, 1948 — envisioned **a library outlet in every village of 1,000–5,000 people**. Gujarat, 76 years on, funds a village library (where one exists) at ₹10,000 a year.
6. **The neglect has a cost.** Gujarat’s children read **below the national average** (NAS 2024, every grade), and its educated young are jobless where it counts — **graduate unemployment 5.0%, women graduates 9.6%**. A starved reading commons is a state under-investing in the people it claims to serve.

1 : 20,000

public libraries per resident
(~3,500 libraries, ~70 m people)

92%

of libraries are grant-in-aid, not
state-run

₹833

per month — the ceiling grant for a
village library

Who runs Gujarat's libraries

The Directorate of Libraries runs 298 libraries directly — two state-central libraries, 26 district and 84 taluka libraries, and a scatter of others. Everything else is **grant-in-aid**: libraries founded and managed by registered societies, panchayats and municipalities, recognised by the state and paid an annual maintenance grant. There are about 3,214 of them. The commons, in other words, is not built by the state — it is delegated to a voluntary sector and subsidised at the state's discretion.

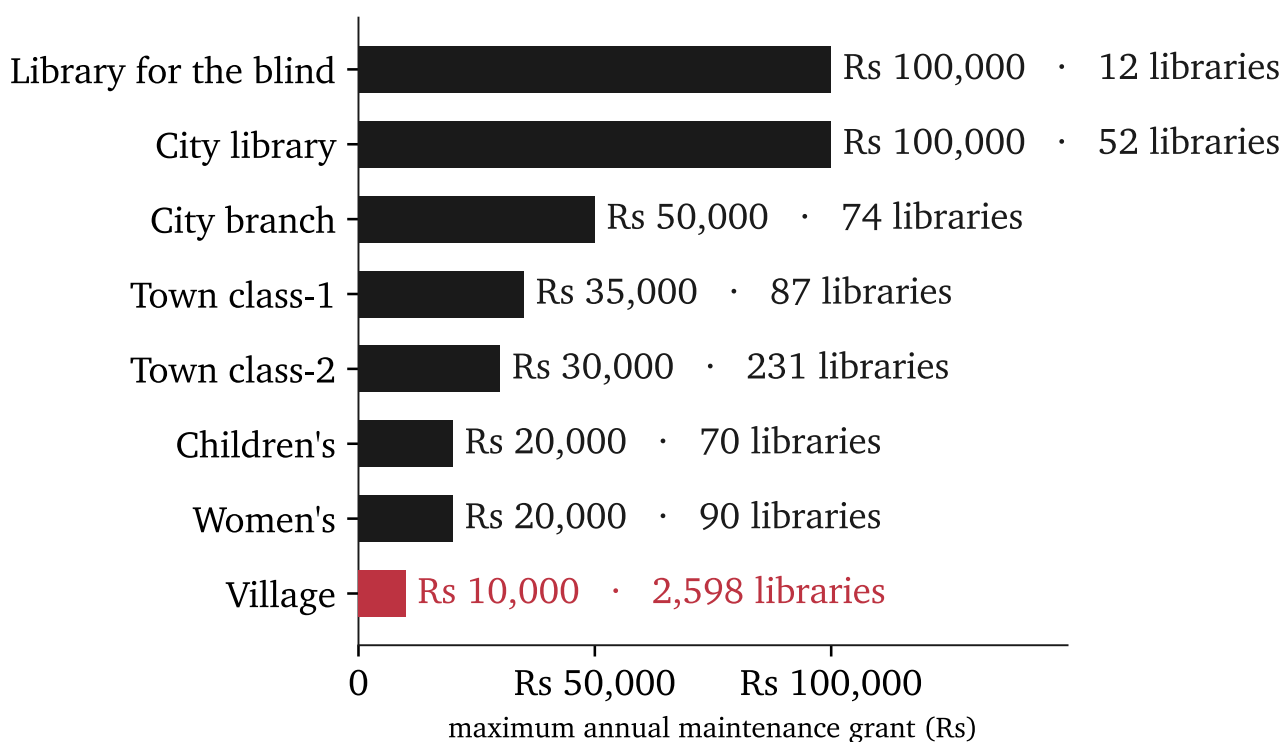
298 government-run (8%)



The state runs 1 in 12. Of ~3,500 public libraries, 298 are government-run and ~3,214 are grant-in-aid. Source: Directorate of Libraries directory, dolib.gujarat.gov.in.

The regressive ladder

Grant-in-aid libraries are paid by a fixed ladder of maximum annual grants, set by category. A city library may draw up to ₹1,00,000; a village library, up to ₹10,000. The ladder's logic is inverted against need: the **most numerous and most rural tier receives the least**. Of the ~3,214 grant-in-aid libraries, 2,598 — eight in ten — are village libraries on the ₹10,000 rung.



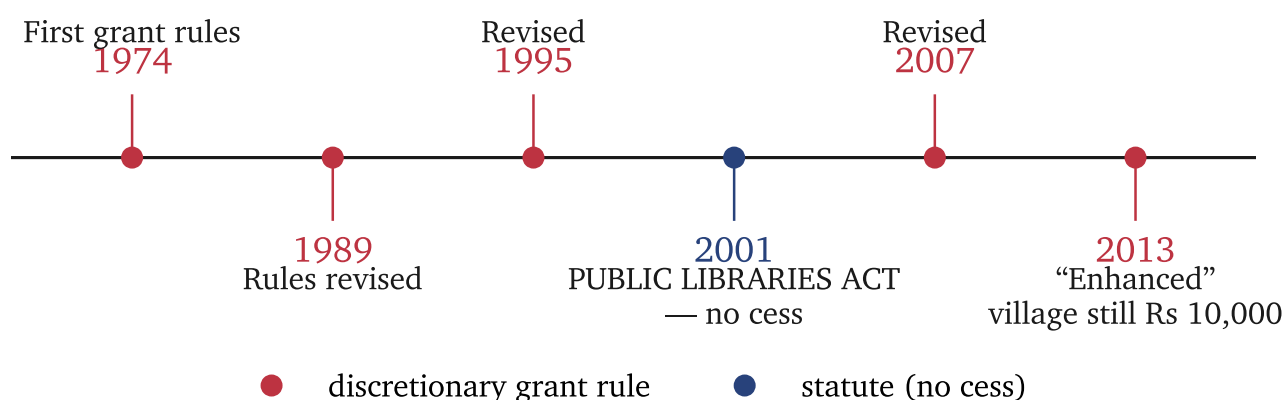
Least where it is needed most. Maximum annual maintenance grant by category, with the number of libraries on each rung. The village tier (red) is both the largest and the lowest-funded. Source: 2013 grant-rules GR (૨૦૧૩-૨૦૧૫-૧૩૮૦-૬) + directory counts.

Category	Libraries	Max grant / year
City library	52	₹1,00,000
Library for the blind	12	₹1,00,000
City branch	74	₹50,000
Town class-1	87	₹35,000
Town class-2	231	₹30,000
Women's	90	₹20,000
Children's	70	₹20,000
Village	2,598	₹10,000

The whole grant-in-aid network — 92% of Gujarat's libraries — would cost the state about **₹4.9 crore a year if every library drew its full ceiling**. That is the *maximum*. Gujarat's entire public-library budget for 2022-23 was about **₹30 crore** (head 2205-00-105); most of it pays the establishment of the 298 government libraries, leaving the grant-in-aid commons on the thin ladder above.

Funding by discretion, never by right

A library cess — as in Tamil Nadu (1948) or Karnataka (1965) — makes reading a claim: a ring-fenced levy the library draws by statute, regardless of any year's goodwill. Gujarat has no cess. Its libraries are funded by a grant scheme first framed in **1974** and re-issued in 1989, 1995, 2007 and 2013 — each revision a renewed discretion, re-verified every five years, not a strengthened right. The **2001 Public Libraries Act** added a State Library Development *Council* — and no fund.



A discretion re-issued, never made law. Grant rules revised five times across 1974–2013; the 2001 Act created a council, not a cess. Source: Gujarat library grant GRs, Directorate of Libraries.

The state's own transparency record confirms the framing. The Directorate's mandatory Right-to-Information disclosure on subsidy programmes states plainly: “*the department does not provide any such subsidy assistance.*” The library grant is administered as departmental housekeeping — not as an entitlement owed to a reading public.

A bill in 1977, a law in 2001

Gujarat was not slow for want of a draft. A **Gujarat Public Libraries Bill — Bill No. 56 of 1977 — was introduced in 1977 and sent to a Select Committee, which reported in 1978.** Then it lapsed. The state did not legislate again until the Gujarat Public Libraries Act, No. 37 of 2001 — a **24-year gap** between the first bill and a law.

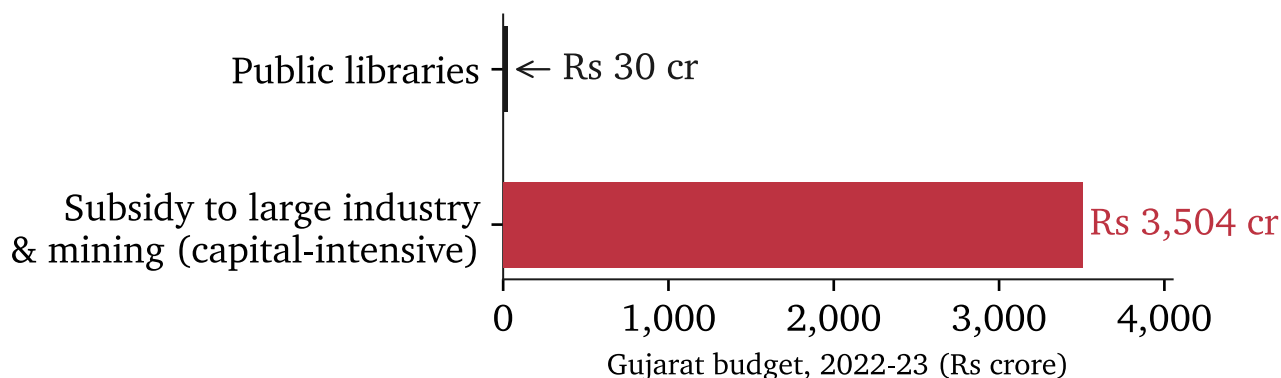
Kerala is the control case. Kerala introduced **its own Public Libraries Bill in the same year, 1977** (Select Committee reported 1979), and enacted the **Kerala Public Libraries Act in 1989 — 12 years,** half Gujarat's wait. Both states began at the same moment, both just after the Emergency (1975–77), a disruption they shared equally. The difference is not circumstance; it is political will. Gujarat's assembly had a public-libraries bill in hand for a generation and let it sit.

The “information turn”

Where new money does appear, it goes to the interface, not the reach. In 2022 the state routed **₹5 crore of unspent grant** into making five *city* district libraries “smart,” and issued RFID member cards for the State Central Library — while the village rung held at ₹10,000. Library development also leans on the Centre: a 2022 order reconstitutes the State Library Committee chiefly to draw the Raja Ram Mohan Roy Library Foundation's **matching grant** from Kolkata. The reader is being upgraded into a card-carrying user of a handful of modernised urban branches; the rural reader is left on the lowest rung.

Austerity for the library, extravagance for capital

The rationing is a choice, and it is visible the moment you set the library beside what the same state hands to capital. This is not an argument against subsidy as such: support to **village and small industry — MSME, khadi, handicraft (₹1,804 crore in 2022-23)** — is labour-intensive and reaches working people, and we do not contest it. The concern is the open hand to *capital*. In the same year its entire public-library budget was about **₹30 crore**, Gujarat budgeted roughly **₹3,500 crore in subsidies to large and medium industry and mining** — capital-intensive support that too often socialises the cost and privatises the gain. That is **about 115 times** what the state spends on every public library it has.



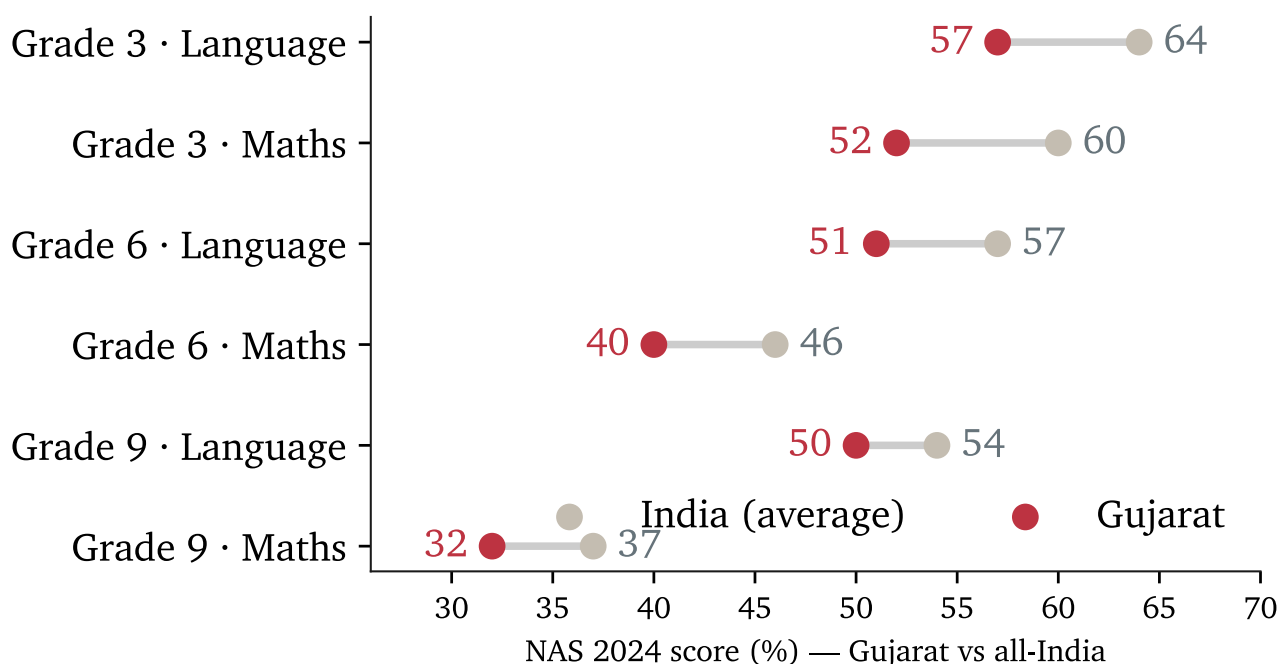
The library budget is a rounding error beside the subsidy to capital. Gujarat budget, 2022-23, ₹ crore. Public libraries (head 2205-00-105) vs subsidy to large & medium industry and mining (heads 2852 + 2853 + 2875); village & small industry (MSME, head 2851) is deliberately excluded. Source: Gujarat Demands for Grants 2022-23.

The austerity is selective — open-handed with capital, tight-fisted with the reading public. The money exists. What is rationed is the library.

Why a ₹10,000 library matters

A reading commons is not an ornament. It is the public infrastructure of comprehension and self-study — the desk the first-generation graduate, the competitive-exam aspirant, and the rural child with no books at home actually depend on. Starve it, and the cost surfaces downstream.

Gujarat's children already read below the national average. On the 2024 national learning survey (PARAKH/NAS), Gujarat trails the all-India score at *every* stage — Grades 3, 6 and 9 — in both language and mathematics, and the gap is widest in the higher grades, exactly where independent reading should be doing its work.



Behind the country at every stage. NAS / PARAKH Rashtriya Sarvekshan 2024 scores (%), Gujarat vs all-India. Gujarat is below the national average in language and mathematics across Grades 3, 6 and 9. Source: PARAKH Rashtriya Sarvekshan 2024.

And the degree does not rescue them. The state's flattering headline — 1.1% unemployment — hides the number that matters: *educated* unemployment. A Gujarat graduate is **5.0%** unemployed, and a woman graduate **9.6%** — four to nine times the headline rate. The more education a young Gujarati buys, the worse her odds.

5.0%

unemployment among Gujarat graduates (PLFS 2023-24)

9.6%

among women graduates — the “degree-but-no-job” gap

below

the national average in NAS 2024, every grade, both subjects

This is the population a working library system serves: the self-taught, the re-skilling, the aspirant who cannot buy a ₹40,000 private-coaching seat. A village library funded at ₹10,000 a year cannot be that infrastructure. The neglect of the reading commons is one face of a wider under-investment in human capital — the same budget that finds ₹3,504 crore for capital finds ₹30 crore for libraries — and the outcomes show it: below-average learning, and degrees that do not lead to work.

What this means

The yardstick is India's own. When India wrote its first public-libraries law — Madras, 1948, the model every later state Act followed — it set a service point for every village of 1,000–5,000 people. Three-quarters of a century later Gujarat has neither met that reach nor funded what it has. The state does not lack the money — the whole society-run commons costs under five crore at its ceiling. It lacks the commitment to fund reading as a right: no cess, a revocable grant network, a ladder that pays least where the rural and Bahujan majority lives, and “development” spent on urban, tech-branded visibility. Gujarat names a library commons it declines to build — and the citizen who might have been a rights-holder becomes a user, served at discretion and abandoned at the margins.

SUGGESTED CITATION The Right to Read Campaign (2026). **The ₹10,000 Library: Gujarat's Public Libraries.** RTR Brief No. 01.

SOURCES All figures derive from primary sources: the Directorate of Libraries, Govt of Gujarat (dolib.gujarat.gov.in) — directory, grant-scheme pages and Government Resolutions (2013 grant-rules GR; 2022 budget GR); the Gujarat Public Libraries Act No. 37 of 2001 and the Madras Public Libraries Act, 1948 (service-point norm); the Directorate's RTI Section-4 disclosure; and the 1977 Select Committee reports (Gujarat Bill 56/1977; Kerala Bill 1977). Budget figures: Gujarat Demands for Grants 2022-23 (BE) — public libraries, head 2205-00-105, ₹30.4 cr; capital-intensive industry & mining = heads 2852 (₹3,257 cr) + 2853 (₹223 cr) + 2875 (₹25 cr) = ₹3,504 cr; village & small industry / MSME, head 2851 (₹1,804 cr), excluded. Learning outcomes: PARAKH Rashtriya Sarvekshan (NAS) 2024, Gujarat & all-India state reports. Educated-unemployment figures: PLFS 2023-24 (MoSPI), graduate UR 5.0% (person) / 9.6% (female). Population: Census 2011 / 2024 estimate. The ₹4.9 cr ceiling, the per-capita ratios, and the ~115× comparison are the campaign's calculations; full provenance in the internal Gujarat dossier.

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